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She was just as fond of guns, horses and tennis as she was of flowers, family and Jaipur.

MAHARANI GAYATRI DEVI (1919-2009)

She was gorgeous, of royal lineage, flamboyant, stylish and unconventional but style to her was never an object of display. She fell in love with her husband, Maharaja Sawai Man Singh II of Jaipur, when she was 12 and he 21. She was the first princess to stand for Parliament, was elected thrice, joined the BJP and did genuine work for Jaipur. *Vogue* magazine had voted her among the 10 most beautiful women in the world.

R. VENKATARAMAN

(1910-2009)

President of India during 1987-92, he worked with four prime ministers and appointed three of them—V.P. Singh, Chandra Shekhar and P.V. Narasimha Rao. The eighth President was elevated from vice-presidency when Rajiv Gandhi was prime minister, succeeding Giani Zail Singh. He was a four-time Lok Sabha MP and a member of the Constituent Assembly that drafted the Constitution.



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LEELA NAIDU (1940-2009)

Femina Miss India 1954, her film debut was in 1960 with *Anuradha* as the bored housewife married to an idealistic doctor. The role won her a National Award. But it was *Yeh Raaste Hain Pyar Ke* (1963) that shot her into the limelight. Drink and doomed marriages affected her later life but she will always be remembered as one of the world's most beautiful women.



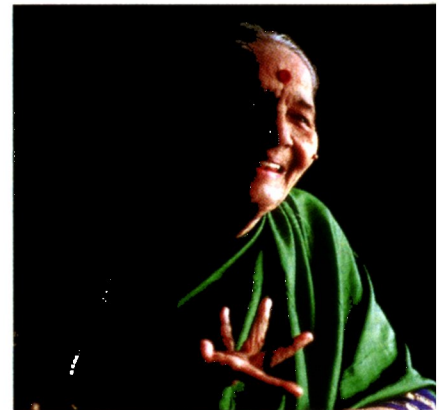
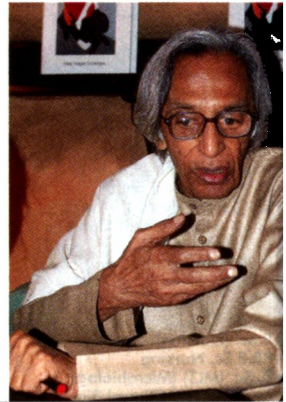
PANJAB PRAKASH/www.indiatodayimages.com

TYEB MEHTA

(1925-2009)

He started as a filmmaker before finding his calling as a painter, expressing deep anguish with diagonals and imagery on matts. His canvas *Celebration* sold for Rs 1.5 crore at Christie's in 2002, breaking the Rs 1-crore barrier for an Indian artist. His *Gesture* sold for Rs 3.1 crore at the Osian auction, the highest an Indian painter's work has ever fetched. During the Partition riots in Mumbai when he was 22, he saw a man being stoned to death by a mob, an image that impacted his art, leading to stark and disturbing imagery. He was awarded the Padma Bhushan in 2007.

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D. K. PATTAMMAL

(1919-2009)

Pattammal, M.S. Subbulakshmi and M.L. Vasanthakumari formed the "female trinity of Carnatic Music", initiating women singers in Carnatic music. She was also a playback singer for films and had won her first singing prize when she was eight. She was also the first woman to have performed Ragam Thanam Pallavi—considered a male dominion—in concerts.